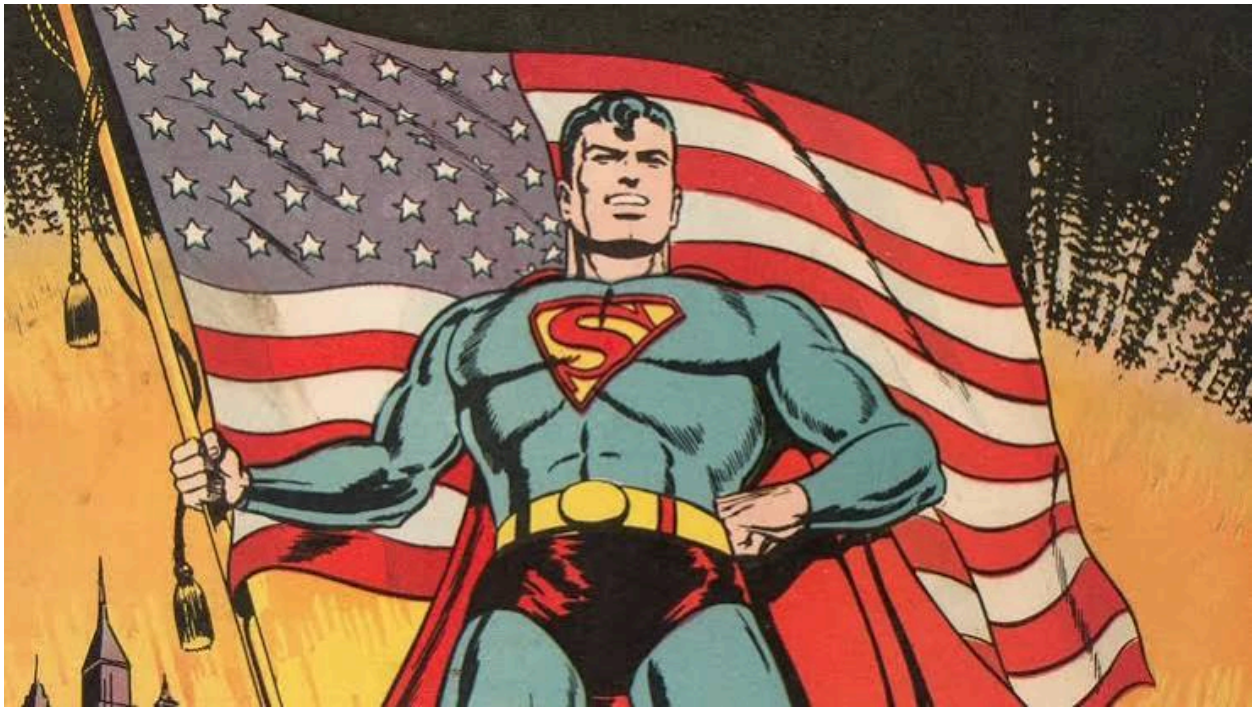
Dr. Gangi-Petit
Advanced American Studies
American Exceptionalism

When you receive this assignment, please make a copy of it, put it in your digital "American Studies" folder, call it "Last name, Superman Assessment" and make sure it is shared with me. Begin writing where it says "begin writing here" below. Then link it to the assignment center on Blackbaud when you are done. Thank you!

It's a bird! It's a plane! It's…Superman!



In his essay "Exceptionalism," Donald E. Pease explains the following:

"The exceptionalist paradigm represented US uniqueness in terms of absent and present elements…the presence of a predominant middle class, tolerance for diversity, upward mobility, hospitality toward immigrants, a shared constitutional faith, and liberal individualism. Exceptionalist historians cited these traits to portray the US nation-state not merely as different from but also as qualitatively better than the European nation-states whose social orders were described as having been devastated by Marxism" (Commager 1947; Hartz 1955; Bell 1960; Lipset 1963).

In a short essay response of two to three double spaced pages, closely read ONE of the following series of panels to explain how they illustrate ONE item from Pease's list. (You can discuss context/the rest of the story, but be sure to focus on closely reading the panels.)

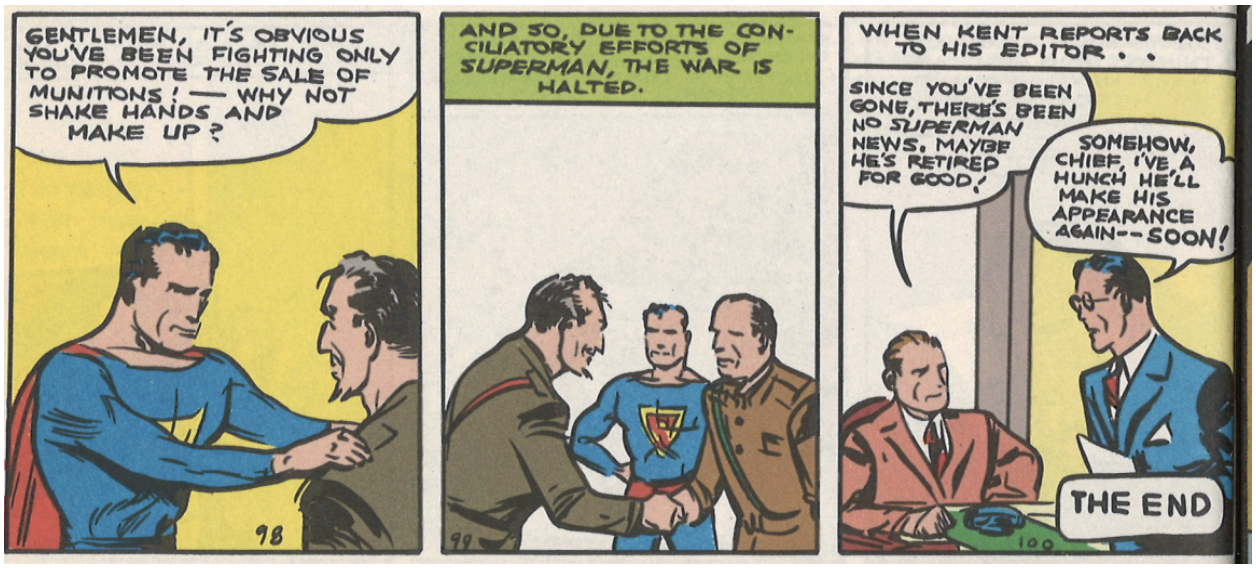
List:

- The presence of a predominant middle class
- Tolerance for diversity
- Upward mobility
- Hospitality towards immigrants
- A shared constitutional faith (implies anti-corruption)
- Liberal individualism
- The U.S as a force for good as opposed to European nation states

Evaluation:

	Excellent	Solid	Approaching Mastery
Claim/ Thesis	You clearly closely read one of the two panels and relate it to Donald Pease's list. Plus, your claim is specific, arguable, and it has stakes. It implicitly answers the question "why does this matter" or "what can we learn from this"?	You clearly focus on one of the two panels and relate it to an item on Donald Pease's list. Your claim is relatively specific.	Your claim may be vague. (For example, you may try to tackle several unrelated items on the list or you may make a very general statement.)
Close Reading/ Analysis	You discuss not only the language but also the images, colors, and positioning of the characters in the panels. **You also discuss the "icon" or "amplification through simplification"**	You discuss the language and images in the text, but there may be more space devoted to summary or context than there is to analysis.	Your discussion is mainly focused on summarizing the context of the panels as opposed to making analytical observations about the panels themselves.
Clarity	Though your timed writing may contain the occasional error, it is generally clear and easy to read. (For example, your pronouns have clear antecedents, your syntax is easy to follow, you don't have dangling modifiers, etc…)	Your timed writing may contain several errors that make it difficult to parse sentences and meaning, but there are still significant clear places and ideas in the text.	Your timed writing may contain many errors and may be quite difficult to follow.

1)



2)



Begin Writing Here:

Panel one illustrates the idea of "The U.S. as a force for good as opposed to European nation-states" through the actions of Superman, an icon of the U.S. Before delving into how the panel supports the thesis, it is important to look at the connection between Superman and America, in particular the idea of American Exceptionalism. In American Exceptionalism, America was "unique" in the sense that it is qualitatively "better" than other nations, especially European nation-states, who were devastated by either feudal hierarchies or communism. This superiority stems from multiple sources, including the structure of the government, the diversity of its citizens, and the common belief held among the people regarding liberal individualism. Superman is often discussed in parallel with the U.S. since he is often regarded as a "hero" who serves as an icon of a force of good, helping the weak, promoting liberal individualism, and resolving conflicts with his superpower.

In panel one, Superman illustrates this idea by resolving a war between two European nation-states. In the first picture, Superman, amplified with more detail, is seen occupying a larger space of the picture. This implies the idea of American dominance. In the second panel, Superman stands straight and watches the two generals shake hands. The generals, on the other hand, were drawn occupying less space and appearing physically weaker than Superman. This strategic technique is intended to make Superman resemble a strong peacemaker, who has the moral high ground(a force of good) and resolves conflicts through a combination of the use of force(violence) and verbal persuasion. This panel also closely ties with the historical background of the story. During the early 1900s, the U.S. participated in two World Wars with the purpose of resolving European conflicts. It joined during the later timeline of World War I to help England and France defeat Germany, while aiding the Allies in World War II to defeat the Axis powers. This directly aligns with the plot of the story, where Superman joins existing conflicts and uses his power to end them. The U.S. claims itself as a conflict "resvoler" going into both wars, connecting with the idea of Superman. Going back to Donald Peace's idea, the U.S., a fundamentally "better" country than European nation-states, often acted as a force of peace to resolve wars inflicted by the force of "evil", which are the symbols of the old European nation-states prominent for the influence of communism and feudal hierarchies.

Honor Code

In completing this assignment, I have upheld the St. Luke's Honor Code.

I have not used any online summaries or **AI content generation tools including large language models for brainstorming, drafting, editing, or any part of the writing process.**

Other than my teacher and any assigned peer feedback partner, I have received assistance on this assignment from:

(if no one, write no one)

By signing or typing my name here, I pledge my honor: